



BEFORE

The steppes and prairies covering much of the Eurasian interior, especially in the west, were suited to varying degrees of farming and grazing.



KURGANS ON THE STEPPES

burial mounds called **kurgans** were a major cultural feature from central Europe to Siberia.

MASS MIGRATION

By c. 2000 BCE a **major movement of steppe peoples** into adjacent lands seems to have begun, linked to **altered agricultural practices** and a search for **better farming conditions**.

BRONZE AGE STEPPE CULTURE

By the Bronze Age **43** the Eurasian steppe peoples were living a mainly **agricultural life**. They kept horses and domesticated animals. Earthen

In geographical terms, the Eurasian steppe can be divided into western and eastern regions. The western area begins in Hungary and stretches north of the Black Sea to the Altai Mountains in the east. The eastern portion, which is mostly at a higher altitude, runs east from the Altai range across Mongolia to Manchuria in China.

The western steppe, such as the fertile lands around the Danube, is wetter and greener. Moving eastward, summers become hotter, winters colder, and rain more scarce. Tribes of the eastern steppe often migrated west or south to areas of higher rainfall and fresh grazing pasture.



Scythian horseman

The Scythians are famed for creating beautiful artifacts, especially in gold, and for being formidable horsemen. This item, found at Kul Oba, in the Crimea, combines both aspects. It dates from the 4th century BCE.

skills were supplemented by a talent for fighting. Steppe society was organized into “kinship” groups (effectively extended families) and tribes. On occasion, tribes might assemble to create a larger body. Such gatherings were usually temporary, formed for a specific purpose, such as defense or attack. The rulers of steppe tribes were often thought to be divine.

Riding to victory

The early history of the horse’s domestication is unclear, but by c. 700 BCE, horses were extremely important on the steppes, and were bred in large numbers. They were

Nomads of the Steppes

The steppes—grasslands stretching from Eastern Europe to China—have been home to nomadic and seminomadic groups for millennia. The history of the steppe people has been influenced by geography, while their territorial ambitions brought clashes with a range of powers that changed the world map.

HOW WE KNOW

THE PAZYRYK TOMBS

Pazyryk is a valley burial site in the Altai Mountains, in modern Kazakhstan, dating from the 5th to 3rd centuries BCE. Much of what we know about the Scythians comes from grave goods discovered in royal kurgans at Pazyryk. These goods included horses, burial chariots, and some of the earliest known textiles—felt and wool items such as appliquéd saddle-covers and colorful carpets (below).



Such migrations reinforced the nomadic lifestyle. It also brought various groups in contact with each other, which is why there are many cultural similarities between the different steppe peoples.

Life on the steppes

Relatively little is known about steppe life before the 11th century CE. We do know that the steppe tribes spoke Indo-European languages, and that

they kept domesticated animals, such as cattle and sheep. They often used animal caravans and rivers to transport goods, and their superb horsemanship

Mongolian herdsman

Nomadic pastoralism involves moving herds of domesticated animals over large distances. In some steppe regions it has changed little in thousands of years.

ideal animals for people who had to move over vast distances to find suitable pasture for their livestock, because they provided not only transportation but also meat and even milk.

By this time, the steppe people could fight very effectively on horseback, possibly having copied the techniques of the Assyrians (see pp.80–81). Crucial to the development of their fighting prowess were the composite

